

Winter Cheat Sheet for Carnivorous Plants

Quick tips for dormancy, repotting & winter care (South Africa edition)

Dormancy 101

- Most temperate carnivorous plants go dormant during winter
- Triggered by the shorter days and colder nights, starting around April in South Africa
- Plants may shrink, go brown, or disappear into bulbs—this is completely normal
- New growth resumes naturally in September to October

Dormancy Summary – What to Expect

These Go Dormant	These Grow Year-Round or Just Slow Down
Venus flytraps	Cape sundews (<i>Drosera capensis</i>)
Trumpet pitcher plants (<i>Sarracenia</i>)	Albany pitcher plants (<i>Cephalotus follicularis</i>)
Purple pitcher plants (<i>Sarracenia purpurea</i>)	Most Bladderworts (<i>Utricularia</i>)
Parrot pitcher plants (<i>Sarracenia psittacina</i>)	Tropical pitcher plants (<i>Nepenthes</i>)
Cobra lilies (<i>Darlingtonia californica</i>)	Pinguicula gigantea and its hybrids
Threadleaf sundews (<i>Drosera filiformis</i>)	Sun pitchers (<i>Heliamphora</i>)
Forkleaf sundews (<i>Drosera binata</i>)	Dewy pines (<i>Drosophyllum lusitanicum</i>)
Some forms of <i>Drosera regia</i> (depending on the clone)	Some forms of <i>Drosera regia</i> (depending on the clone)
All temperate and most Mexican butterworts (<i>Pinguicula</i>)	
Some forms of <i>Aldrovanda</i> (waterwheel plants)	

Side Note: Summer Dormancy

- Some carnivorous plants go dormant in summer, not winter. These include:
 - Winter-growing sundews like *Drosera cistiflora* and tuberous sundews
 - Rainbow plants (*Byblis* species)
- They rest during hot, dry weather and return to growth in the cooler months

Seasonal Growth Cycle (South African Climate)

- **Sep–Nov:** Emerging from dormancy (first signs of new traps and leaves appearing)
- **Dec–Feb:** Peak growing season (plants are actively growing and feeding)
- **Mar–May:** Winding down (growth slows, some traps start to die back)
- **Jun–Aug:** Full dormancy (not growing actively — expect reduced growth or full dieback above the soil)

What Dormant Plants Look Like

- **Venus flytraps:** ground-hugging traps or an [underground bulb](#) with tiny traps just above the soil
- **Trumpets, purple pitchers & parrot pitchers:** brown, dry leaves with a healthy crown hidden below
- **Temperate sundews & butterworts:** may vanish completely or form [tight rosettes](#)

Winter Do's & Don'ts

✓ Do	✗ Don't
Divide and trim dormant plants (July–Aug)	Repot tropical species — rather wait for early spring
Reduce watering, but don't let pots dry out	Keep pots soggy or keep in standing water
Label plants when trimming back old growth	Assume a bulb is dead—they hide well!
Let plants rest – inspect for pests and no feeding	Put them in the fridge – they still need natural light, even during dormancy

Why Winter Is Great for Ordering

- Less moisture means lower shipping weight and delivery costs!
- Dormant plants transplant better with minimal stress
- Plants settle in quietly and wake up happy in spring!
- Potted plants from us and [in-store](#) are already transplanted into fresh carnivorous plant soil and ready for the new growing season!

Repotting & Dividing Tips

- Divisions: Best done while plants are completely dormant (May to August)
- Repotting: Repot yearly into [fresh carnivorous plant soil](#) – wait until August to early spring, unless there's a specific issue (e.g. root rot, mold or pests)
- Spring warmth helps plants bounce back faster
- I offer repotting services and winter consultations if you'd like personalised help

Need Help?

Not sure what your plant needs this winter? I offer [personal consults](#) and [repotting services](#) to help you prep for spring.

Want something that looks awesome year-round? Join a [terrarium workshop](#) or request a custom terrarium build — perfect for home, workspaces, or unique gifts!

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